



GRACE IN MOVEMENT

A look inside Mumbai’s pioneering ballet school and its enduring 60-year legacy **P3**



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“Formidable woman,” a character in *The Bluff* says, describing Ercell ‘Bloody Mary’ Bodden. At the helm of things in Prime Video’s latest swashbuckler action thriller, actor Priyanka Chopra Jonas has quite the task at hand.

As a former pirate who has to contend with her past when a gang of ruthless, bloodthirsty buccaneers invade her island, Priyanka’s Ercell wields a sword and a gun with equal ease, takes down the bad guys with precision, and is seemingly well-prepared for whatever bloody confrontations await, including a big one with Captain Connor (Karl Urban).

When the film’s first trailer dropped, fan comments could not help but draw Priyanka and Karl’s star characters from their respective shows, *Quantico* and *The Boys*. “The Butcher is hunting down Alex Parrish,” a cheeky comment read.

The Bluff, which Priyanka has co-produced alongside the Russo Brothers, was shot over two-and-a-half months in Australia following many weeks of training, the star reveals. “It was definitely a very physically demanding role. It required a lot of agility from me and because it was a dramatic performance, you also needed my face in the camera because the story was still going forward,” she says.

Filming the extensive stunts, Priyanka says, involved a lot of focus and work. “You can get injured very easily. For instance, the house we shot in was very small. There was furniture, cameras, and a crew. There were a lot of bruises and splinters but there was not anything serious thank God,” she smiles.

In the film, Priyanka flees the buccaneers with her



family in tow; her sister-in-law and her young son. During an initial ambush in the film, the actor, whose clothes are soaked through with blood and is wielding a gun, instantly snaps from fierce to comforting as she reassures her horrified son. “I’m glad you caught that,” she says. “I might be fighting people, but I’m still talking to my son. I might be fighting people, but I’m still thinking of where the next person is. It wasn’t just about slow-motion action sequences; it was real. This required a lot more as an actor from me and of course, I love the challenge of that,” she says.

This is particularly significant for the actor given how she was filming *The Bluff* as a new mother. Her daughter, Malti Marie Chopra Jonas, was around two-years-old when they were shooting for the film. “*The Bluff* was physically tough, yes. But what really moved me was the thought of how far a woman would go or a parent to protect their child. I was a new mother at that time and I knew that feeling very well. So I really applied it to the movie,” she says.

With her last few releases being the Prime Video film *Heads of State* opposite Idris Elba and John Cena, the romantic comedy *Love Again* and the spy thriller show *Citadel*, the actor has been

enjoying a notably action-packed run.

“I was in fact shooting for *Heads of State* till a few weeks before I started filming *The Bluff*. I had the same stunt coach on both films, Anisha Gibbs and whenever we would have a break while filming *Heads Of State*, we would practise with our swords,” she reveals.

Priyanka made her debut in the 2002 Tamil film *Thamizhan*, opposite actor Vijay and in the 24 years since, has racked up every genre you can possibly think of to her extensive filmography. She played the villain with ease in *Aitraaz*, was a part of the *Krrish* superhero franchise, has dabbled in science-fiction, played multiple characters in a single film, and continues to shine in character-backed roles across the spectrum; be it as Kashibai in the period-film *Bajirao Mastani* or as the rich and savvy girlboss Aysha in *Dil Dhadakne Do*.

Her upcoming project *Varanasi*, SS Rajamouli’s magnum opus where she stars alongside Mahesh Babu and Prithviraj is touted to be an epic, action-adventure film, a film Priyanka described on the red-carpet premiere of *The Bluff* as ‘career-defining’.

As fans celebrate 20 years of the *Krrish* franchise, and older hits like ‘Saajan Saajan Saajan’ from her film *Barsaat* trend on Instagram, we ask how her approach to the craft has evolved in bringing these diverse women to life on screen. “Everything has evolved except one thing, which is really delving into your character’s truths and why they are doing what they are doing in a movie. Not what I look like, not the clothes I’m wearing, but the choices that my character is making. So, why would they wear these shoes, or why would they have this hair or why would they have this weapon? What do they need it for? Where do they come from?” she says.

In *The Bluff*, Priyanka says that she loves how she is fighting to protect her family and the reason she can survive is because of her family. “She has escaped the worst life to be able to have a simple life, and this simple life is what gives her so much. There is just such beauty in what we all are looking for, to find our *do gay zameen* and what belongs to us,” she says, emphasising on how she loves this depth that the story holds.

The film also marks a milestone for Priyanka, who dons several hats including that of an entrepreneur and producer. While she has produced several films through her banner Purple Pebble Pictures, the star shared photos from the red carpet premiere of *The Bluff* on Thursday and said that this was the first film that she has produced and led from the US.

“While I have produced films before, this time, I was involved from the very beginning and was actually treated as a collaborator. Whether it’s Prime Video, or the Russos or even Frank E Flowers, the director; none of them needed to have included me from the first edit to the last. But they really brought me in, and into every department and through all the choices that were being made,” she said.

This, Priyanka says, ensured she felt invested in every aspect of the film and to make sure that everyone was taken care of. “All of that is very interesting to me. I love the art, business and history of entertainment. I am glad to be able to do this, as an actor and a producer,” she says.

PRIYANKA CHOPRA JONAS
Actor-producer

The *Bluff* streams on Prime Video from February 25

pick of the week



Sweet start

This Ramzan, Jakobi Chocolatier has launched a Ramadan Advent Calendar, offering a 30-day chocolate experience designed to accompany the holy month. The calendar features

handcrafted selections including pistachio kunafa, sea-salted caramel, honeyed ganache, tropical fruit infusions, dates and almonds. Each chocolate comes with a note on daily reflection and mindfulness. Priced ₹2,500, the calendar is available at jakobi.in.



On screen

Lights, camera, passport! The Indo Cine Appreciation Foundation's Festival of Festival Films 2026 lands in Chennai, bringing six globe-trotting gems from Montenegro to Australia. The

festival highlights award-winning cinema spanning drama, romance, and social commentary, including Montenegro's Oscar entry *The Tower of Strength* and CIFF awardee *Riverstone*. From February 23 to 25 at PVR INOX Sathyam, Royapettah.



Shopping list

To sort out shopping plans this weekend, Dreamcatcher Events brings Spring Edit '26, a curated food, fashion and lifestyle popup bringing together over 30 women-run brands from Chennai, Kochi,

Jaipur, Kolkata and beyond. Expect a vibrant showcase of apparel for men, women and children, silver and fashion jewellery, home décor, kids' stationery, skincare, handbags, and tarot readings. Today, from 10.30am onwards at the Folly, Amethyst, Royapettah.



Chennai rock

Chennai's live-music scene welcomes a fresh acoustic highlight with Back at the Shack. The event will feature Rohan Sen, Vikram Vivekanand and Vinay

Ramakrishnan, founders of the rock outfit Grey Shack. Audiences can expect classic rock staples — from Elvis Presley to Led Zeppelin as well as select Grey Shack favourites. Today at Kat and Kin Coffee Roasters, Neelankarai, 11am onwards. Tickets at ₹499 on BookMyShow.com

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Everyone has an opinion about kink, and almost none of them begin with, "I'm curious." The first time it came up with my friends, it was over dessert, which feels appropriate because Indians love processing discomfort with sugar. Someone asked, genuinely alarmed, "So it's basically just hurting people, right?" Another waved their spoon dismissively and said, "Wasn't that *Fifty Shades*?" And that was that.

Here's the first myth to dismantle: kink in India is not one thing. It's not a dungeon, it's not a personality type, and it's definitely not eight shades of collective moral panic. At its most basic, kink is a set of preferences, practices, and agreements about power and pleasure. Over the past few years, communities have been forming, people have been comparing notes, and yes, India even had its first Kink Con a few years ago.

So why do we still get it wrong? Shame. We inherit it like furniture. Our first reference point is usually spectacle. Strip away the theatrics, though, and kink is aggressively practical. It's about safewords, checking in, aftercare, and saying things out loud that most of us would rather assume. In her book *Speak Easy*, sex educator Seema Anand says it plainly: consent isn't a one-time "yes"; it's an ongoing conversation.

But communication isn't the whole story; otherwise, Indians would simply WhatsApp their way into better sex and be done with it.

A married woman I spoke to told me kink did something unexpected in her marriage: it made her husband ask. Constantly. "Are you okay?" She laughed when she said it and then added, "That level of attention was the most romantic thing he's done in years."

A young, queer man in Bengaluru told me kink forced him to stop blaming "chemistry" for every failed hookup. "We say there's no spark," he said, "When what we really mean is we didn't talk."

The first time someone asked him what he actually wanted, he



ILLUSTRATION: SAAI

THE NAKED TRUTH

Permission slip

From shame and misconceptions to consent, curiosity and pleasure, Indians are open to conversations about kink in the bedroom

froze. "I realised I'd spent years performing desire without knowing my own."

Kink, for him, was less a fantasy and more a mirror.

Don't hit the panic button

Which brings us to the question everyone usually panics about: pain and pleasure. How do you tell the difference without turning intimacy into a corporate offsite? You use signals.

Safewords are the obvious ones — "red" means stop, "yellow" means slow down — but when speech isn't an option, people agree on non-verbal cues: dropping an object, tapping a hand, a gesture that says pause. Experienced practitioners talk about watching breathing, responsiveness, and energy.

And yes, pain can be part of pleasure, but distress is something else entirely. Freezing, shutting down, going silent: that's

your cue to stop. After that comes aftercare: water, warmth, reassurance, and a conversation once everyone's nervous system calms down. Which, frankly, is more emotional responsibility than most of us were taught in any context.

A necessary disclaimer: kink is not a cure-all. It won't fix a marriage that avoids conversations about money or childcare any more than yoga will if you never leave your house. But it does teach habits most relationships desperately need: how to ask, how to listen, and how to care once the mood has passed.

As a kink practitioner once told me, to simplify my understanding of it: think of kink like ordering a *thali*. "You negotiate the spice level, respect when someone's had enough, and agree upfront on whether dessert is shared. But if you want to be serious, treat it like any other skill worth learning — with curiosity, humility, and the ability to stop when someone says stop."

As Aili Seghetti, who leads Intimacy Curator, that organises kink events pan India, once told me on the sidelines of a foot fetish cruise she organised in Mumbai a few years ago, we have to be open about basic fetishes first before getting into more intense territory. "We need to be open to discussing our desires, and less judgment helps."

"The cruise had around 60 people. Most kink events we organise typically draw between 60 and 80 attendees. Femdom suppers — where women hold the power and their subjects (mostly men) join them — are among the most popular, with a waiting list of nearly two months," Aili tells me.

We've avoided these conversations because they're messy, and because shame is often easier than curiosity. The good news is that curiosity is catching up. People are learning, communities are forming, and educators are finally saying things out loud.

A fortnightly guide to love in the age of bare minimum



(Left) The transformed Ferrari; (below from left) Raghava KK; Madhuri Dixit; and Dr Shriram Nene. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

conversations — on technology, art and cinema — between the artist and the family.

For Dr Nene, this collaboration has been special. He explains how conversations with the artist have translated into elements on the car, "He (Raghava) has Albert Einstein holding a spark plug. He has the boys in their various avatars, and one of my new projects called Pathfinder is featured prominently on the car." The car also features Dr Nene and his wife, Madhuri Dixit Nene, in spacesuits, with the line, 'To Infinity and Beyond'. "As a family, it brings us together as a unifying theme, and we race together, so this became our life story in our car," explains Dr Nene.

For Ferrari, this kind of artist collaboration was a first, and from initial responses, a success. "From Benedetto Vigna, CEO, Ferrari, to everyone we've shown this to, they have been blown away by what this brings together. On the track, the car looks magnificent," says Dr Nene.

For Raghava, creating a livery design on a race car was not the same as creating on canvas or screen. The technical specifications of the machine, the position of various elements had to closely tie in with how the car would look stationary and zipping past others on the track. The art had to encapsulate storytelling. "In India, we have everything that makes us a beautiful collage, so in this design, there's juxtaposition and harmony of imagination and precision, like an expressive emotional collage," says the artist.

Expressing how art is an amalgam and echoing Raghava's sentiments, Dr Nene concludes, "I think art should be equal parts science, motivation, beauty, as well as speed and technology. And this car, kind of, brings it together."



the Ferrari, it becomes an Indian aesthetic in motion. "The double-headed tiger is a motif I created to hold together the contradictions of being human. It embodies a duality.

The car also features Dr Nene and his wife, Madhuri Dixit Nene, in spacesuits



Art for the track

Artist Raghava KK transforms Dr Shriram Nene's Ferrari 296 GT3 into a tiger-striped tribute to the family

Anisha Menezes

A race car is already considered a work of art. How, then, do you create art on it? That was both the calling and challenge for Raghava KK, a contemporary Indian artist, as he set out to transform a Ferrari 296 GT3. Bengaluru-based Raghava, who is known for his hand-painted, digital and mixed media art, created a 'hero backstory' for Mumbai-based Dr Shriram Nene, a cardio-thoracic surgeon and healthcare innovator, his wife, actor Madhuri Dixit Nene and their sons Arin and Ryan, on their Ferrari.

Raghava who has known the Nene family for over a decade, explains how this machine became his muse, and speed met storytelling, "We had an amazing collaborator in UK-based automotive designer

Keith Wood (from Hype Creative, a motorsport graphic design company), who gave me the livery rules. First, we did 2D and 3D renders. Over a white base, I designed the motifs, elements and palette, some hand-painted, and the others digital. The entire artwork was transferred onto a vinyl skin that went over the body of the car."

At the centre is Raghava's signature double-headed tiger, which symbolises the tension between engineering and emotion. When draped across

Shyama Panikkar
SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



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Chennai's young readers and music lovers are in for a unique treat this weekend as author and music educator Shyama Panikkar launches her latest children's book, *Ta Ka Dhi Mi 2358*, by Sur Taal aur Masti, to the city.

Shyama's fourth publication for children, is designed for children in the age group between 6 and 12 years. The book explores an unusual but engaging theme — the connection between mathematics and music. At the heart of the story is a young boy who adores music but

struggles with math. When his teacher introduces him to the Fibonacci series and demonstrates how its patterns can be transformed into rhythm using konnakol, the spoken language of rhythm in Indian classical music, the boy begins to see numbers in a new light.

Through storytelling, she illustrates how patterns such as the Fibonacci sequence appear not only in Nature but also in musical structures, turning what is often perceived as a difficult subject into an artistic adventure.

Founder of Sur Taal aur Masti, Shyama has been conducting innovative workshops that make music education interactive and enjoyable. The Chennai launch will feature an interactive session where children will explore the idea of 'Mathemusic', creating rhythm through numbers, followed by a live classical music performance by her students, accompanied by a tabla artiste.

At Odyssey Bookstore, Adyar. February 22, 5pm. To register visit urbanaut.app

(Right) Dancers of the School of Classical Ballet and Western Dance; (below) Tushna (seated third from left) with students; and Tushna with Khushcheher. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



Riddhi Doshi

Her spine erect, neck elongated, legs crossed, torso slightly tilted and chin held high, she sits on a plastic chair. Her right arm extends, slightly arched, moving slowly from her head to her waist. It is a ballet move, but Khushcheher Dallas, 52, is simply gesturing for me to take the chair across from her for the interview. That poise never leaves her, even when she is not on stage. It comes from over 30 years of teaching ballet and years devoted to learning the form. Her first teacher was her mother, the legendary Tushna Dallas, who established The School of Classical Ballet and Western Dance in 1966, widely regarded as the first formal ballet school in Mumbai. From choreographers Shiamak Davar and Ashley Lobo to actors Ayesha Dharker, Perizaad Zorabian and Tara Sutaria, generations have learnt to arabesque at Tushna’s Girgaum studio. Over the last six decades, the

institution has sculpted thousands of bodies, shaped careers, and instilled the discipline that ballet demands. “Tushna was a gentle yet demanding taskmaster,” says James D’Silva, 60, founder of the UK-based Garuda Studio, which helps dancers, performers and athletes recover from physical injuries through bodywork. He has trained several global personalities, including Madonna.

The boy from Goa James trained with Tushna for a year before dancing with international ballet companies and later creating one of his own. “Her solid technique became the foundation of my career,” he adds. She recognised his talent early, took a boy from a Goan village under her wing, nurtured him, and

pushed him to achieve more. “She was always happy to hear about what I was doing next. It was almost as if she was vicariously living through me.” Tushna never



Founded in 1966, the School of Classical Ballet and Western Dance has trained generations of performers and shaped Mumbai’s relationship with ballet

became a professional ballet dancer herself. At the time, ballet was a lesser known discipline in India and no one taught the form here. When she turned 16 and her parents agreed to let her study abroad, it was too late; ballerinas typically begin training at four or five. She chose instead to train as a ballet teacher at the London School of Dance and Drama (now the Imperial Society of

open



Teachers of Dancing). Initially, her trainers were unsure whether a brown girl from India could keep up. She was placed on probation for a few months. “Her white batchmates would ask if she even knew what a fridge was,” recalls Khushcheher. They assumed she came from a backward country. “But soon enough, she was teaching her classmates and helping them study,” she adds.

Tushna graduated at the top of her class – “no small feat,” says Khushcheher. Yet she returned to India. “She could not stay and work abroad because there was pressure to get married,” adds James. Back home, Tushna brought the same rigour, discipline and passion to Mumbai, opening a school with just four students. At the time, ballet shoes were unavailable in the city; a skilled bus conductor doubled up as a cobbler for her.

Word slowly spread – about her teaching, and about how ballet helped children build focus and discipline. Enrolments grew. “I don’t have an exact count, but thousands of students must have passed through the school,” says Khushcheher. Tushna often taught pro bono. “If someone couldn’t afford the fees but showed potential, she would train them for free. That’s how passionate she was.” She taught and danced until two days before giving birth to her daughter.

In the early years, persuading parents to enrol their children was difficult and the school grew slowly. Yet Tushna would sometimes politely discourage students from joining. “For her, it was never about money or numbers. If she felt

someone didn’t have the physical build for ballet – like an arched foot – she would ask them to direct their energy elsewhere,” says Khushcheher.

The challenges Khushcheher has been teaching since she was 19 and has inherited the same integrity and rigour. “I don’t compromise on technique or discipline either,” she says. California-based dancer Matisse Love, formerly with a Russian ballet company, agrees. “The students’ technique is excellent. They look together, disciplined and in sync.” Matisse, with dancer Harry Peterson, performed at the school’s 60th anniversary celebration at St Andrew’s Auditorium in Bandra in December – a show conceptualised by Khushcheher.

Khushcheher herself trained as a teacher at the Royal Academy of Dance, London, on a scholarship. After completing the course, she returned to Mumbai to continue her mother’s legacy. Challenges remain. Enrolling male students is one. “Earlier, parents hesitated to enrol girls. Now we struggle to get boys. Ballet is still not seen as suitable for them,” she says.

Space is another concern. The studio is rented, limiting structural modifications. “We have to restrict jumps because mats cannot replace a sprung floor, which absorbs shock and prevents injuries,” she explains. Despite this, students perform well in Royal Academy examinations. “But we could do much better – jump higher – with the right floor.”

As Khushcheher works towards that goal, her students continue to train with dedication. Sahana Kamdar and Aryana Mehta, both 18, have studied ballet here for 12 years. Rain or shine, even during Board exams, they rarely miss class. “It’s such an integral part of our lives that when we don’t dance, we feel incomplete,” says Sahana. “It’s also a way to step away from studies and focus on what we love,” adds Aryana, who hopes to become a professional dancer.

Many of Tushna and Khushcheher’s students have gone on to join international companies or open their own studios in Mumbai and beyond. In doing so, they carry forward a legacy that has quietly shaped the city’s dance culture for over six decades.

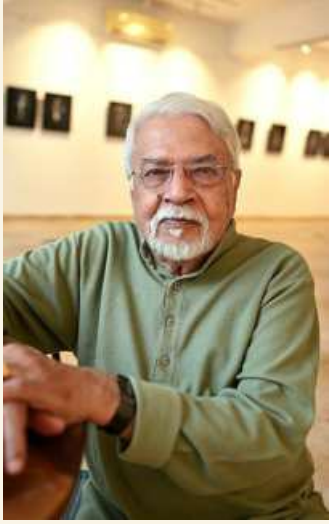
Nurturing artistic voices

Arnawaz Vasudev Charities will host its biannual art camp at Cholahmandal Artists’ Village from February 21-24

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For over 25 years, Arnawaz Vasudev Charities has quietly supported and attempted to encourage the individualistic voices of Indian artists trying to navigate an increasingly complex world. Founded in 1989 by renowned painter SG Vasudev in memory of his wife Arnawaz, the trust was envisioned as a way to give back to the artistic community. Today, it has supported nearly 200 artists, many of whom have gone on to establish strong professional practices, says BO Shailesh, one of the trustees with visible pride.

Arnawaz Vasudev Charities is back with its biannual camp at Cholahmandal Artists’ Village, where selected artists are invited to stay for four days, with accommodation, materials and space provided. The camp will begin on February 21, followed by an artists’ presentation on February 22 at Laburnum and Indigo galleries. The camp is set to end on February 24. The participating artists this year are Meera Unnikrishnan, Rakesh Kumar, Ranganath Amrad, Sreelakshmi KS and Veeresh Rudraswami. Speaking on the success of the camps, Shailesh says, “Ninety per cent of the artists are now in a very good position. That is one of the prides of our charity.” Each year, the trust awards scholarships to around eight-12 artists. It also extends assistance to art students with



SG Vasudev. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

financial impediments. “If anybody gets a scholarship abroad and needs help, we have supported a couple of artists by giving their flight ticket,” he explains. The aim is not simply to fund projects but to remove barriers that might prevent promising artists from advancing. The camp is designed as spaces of experimentation, dialogue and exchange, where young practitioners can test ideas without commercial pressure. “In return, we don’t take any of their artworks. We don’t acquire anything. This is purely supporting artists,” Shailesh says.

The founding trustees of the camp are Shanta Guhan, Girish Karnad and SG Vasudev and the present trustees are BO Shailesh, Bharani V Setlur, Mala Chinnappa, RM Palaniappan and SG Vasudev.



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Think back to what you wore to school. Crisp shirts, starched pinafores, bright white socks, and of course, a pair of smart, shiny black Mary Jane shoes. The shoe carries unmistakable girlhood nostalgia, and over the last few years, has made a noticeable return to everyone’s closets; in a spectrum of colours, bolder prints and with shinier buckles.

A limited-edition merchandise collaboration between Johnnie Walker Blonde Non-Alcoholic Lemonade and New Delhi-based designer Dhruv Kapoor now has Mary Janes take the spotlight, with the vision of celebrating individual style and self-expression.

“For me, working on the collaboration was about freedom of expression and progress. That is how we work on design as a brand as well,” says Dhruv, of their shared beliefs.

This time around, the Mary Janes are not just for the girls. Made of

Sole design

Designer Dhruv Kapoor takes us through creating hybrid Mary Janes for a collaboration with Johnnie Walker Blonde Non-Alcoholic Lemonade, and his New Delhi flagship store

handcrafted leather in blue with a pop of yellow on the insoles, the hybrid shoes are a reflection of Dhruv’s design language, which champions modern dressing, androgynous silhouettes and gender-fluid dressing.

“Mary Janes were traditionally associated or rigid towards being a feminine shoe. I wanted to pick up something that has that rigid association and re-perceive it,” Dhruv says. “We picked up the women’s uniform shoe, and the men’s shoe or what I wore; a traditional Oxford or a

brogue, and the collaborative result was this,” he adds.

The shoes come in an electric blue padded backpack, which comes with colourful detachable charms and enamel pins.

2026 began with the designer opening his first flagship store in New Delhi. Conceiving this space and seeing it come to life is something that has

(Clockwise from left) The hybrid Mary Jane shoes; padded backpack for the shoes; and Dhruv Kapoor. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



the designer excited, as he describes working on it at length.

“For me it was more about expanding the experience of the brand. We have not had a direct presence or an experience that is directly curated and controlled by the brand before this. The flagship store for me was to share the values of the brand. Now, these are not really tangible but my team and I sat down with the architects to make this come through,” Dhruv says.

“You are free to pause and to go at your own pace and connect with the brand in whichever format you like. It is about easing out, and making the whole experience a calm one. We wanted this to be more powerful than simply buying and selling,” he adds. The curation at



the store, the designer says, is of a much wider range with many different kinds of textiles and menswear, which customers in the past only had access to through his online store.

New collection At the end of the month, Dhruv reveals that a new collection is on its way. “I started thinking about it when I was coming back from Milan after my show. I was waiting to board the flight and was observing the people around; how they respond when you put them in a space of transit or a minimal space, how the body language changes and the existence of a common shared language amongst everybody which is just with expressions,” he says, of what set off the spark.

“Somebody is running to catch their flight, someone with a lot of time is at ease, and another person is surrounded by chaos because their kids are with them. These are some characters we have infused into the collection, in a more refined way so that it looks cohesive,” Dhruv adds.

We circle back to Mary Janes; who does Dhruv see wearing these new shoes? “Just off my head, Saif Ali Khan. The shoes are comfortable and laidback, something you can spend your day in. Alia Bhatt is going to love it as well. When we were building it, it was never gendered or even specifically for someone; we never put the audience into a box,” Dhruv says.

“If you know the person is playful enough to experiment or is wanting to express themselves a certain way free of rigidity, they are definitely going to pounce at something like this,” he adds.

The shoes are priced at ₹22,500 and are available on dhruvkapoor.com



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Unpopular opinion: Osaka > Tokyo. Admittedly, Tokyo is fantastic, futuristic, sweeping you up with its quick pace, trendy districts like Ginza, immersive art exhibitions, bustling nightlife and food scene. The vibe, I thought, was unmatched, till I reached Osaka. This port city has me wrapped around its little finger. I do not know if it is the laid-back charm, the geniality of the locals, their interesting fashion choices (I saw a lot of pinks, from candy floss and neon to raspberry and fuchsia), the food scene, or the shopping. The gamut of experiences here range from traditional tea ceremonies, peaceful shrine visits, and sumo experiences to Mario kart tours, and bar hopping to *izakayas*. Sensing its potential, luxury hotel chains and bars are investing in real estate in Osaka. The Four Seasons Hotels and Resorts opened its first outpost here in 2024. Gucci unveiled its Gucci Giardino bar last year in the Umeda district, said to be the second-ever after Florence.

Neon lights and

kushikatsu bites

But my first stop is a dungeon: one that lets me swipe my credit card. Tucked below six interconnected Umeda stations in the area, is a world I never expected. I follow the steps and enter a bustling underground world commonly known as Umeda Dungeon – a network of shopping malls, stores, and diners. Yes, you will get lost and find yourself emerging out of one of the five other stations but wherever you are you will always be ensconced in the comfort of retail therapy. I highly recommend the Lucua complex that houses two buildings brimming with boutiques showcasing local designers and international brands. Post this, I find myself entering Don Quijote, the store where chaos meets consumerism. Popularly known as Donki, this is a discount store chain with multiple floors brimming with cosmetics, skin care, electronics, snacks, costumes, pre-loved bags and no clear instructions on where to find an escalator or steps to move up to the next floor. I



spend two hours at Donki but in hindsight, I would have liked to spend that time at the Umeda Dungeon. As I walk the streets, the traditional-modern fusion becomes more apparent. An example is the Four Seasons Osaka that I check into. While the hotel is glitzy with all the trappings of modern life, an entire floor is dedicated to the

traditional Japanese style of living. Titled ‘Gensui’ Modern Ryokan floor, it has rooms with tatami flooring where you walk barefoot, a low bed with a special futon, and a bathroom with a deep square tub, a stool, and Japanese bath bucket. The windows overlook the Osaka skyline that dazzles at night with its shiny high rise buildings. The breakfast area on

this floor serves Japanese staples in bento boxes, and you can also try your hand at traditional arts like origami, kirigami etc. Like a movie set The next morning I am up early to explore the city. A private Four Seasons boat steers me around the Dojima river as we pass by the Osaka Castle, parks,

gardens and dancing fountains. From this sanctuary of calm, I proceed to the vibrant, in-your-face district of Shinsekai. Exuding a carnival vibe, this place pulses with retro-style shops, old school arcade games, game stalls, street food counters with bright boards and installations, and lanterns sporting bold Japanese letters. It resembles a meticulously put-together movie set from the 1980s. And here, I meet Billiken – a portly creature with a tuft of conical hair, pointed ears and an impish grin. He is considered to be a symbol of good fortune and is everywhere – on facades of buildings, keychains, T-shirts, you name it. Though quite the hero in Osaka, it is said Billiken was created by Florence Pretz, an American illustrator in the early 1900s. Eat, shop, repeat Peckish, I do what I am primarily here to do – grab a variety of highly-recommended kushikatsu (deep-fried meat and veggies on skewers): shiitake mushroom, lotus root, cheese, sausage, chicken thigh. More options await down the alley. Gyoza, takoyaki (wheat balls filled with minced octopus, pickled ginger, green onion and tempura scraps),

nikujaga (meat and potato stew), okonomiyaki (a savoury pancake), and something that resembles a South Indian *kozhukattai*. The food here is so popular that there are local guides offering much recommended food walks. No wonder, Osaka is called the ‘kitchen of Japan’. Shinsekai was built in 1912, inspired by New York’s Coney Island and Paris. The Paris reference becomes clear once I notice the 108-metre tall Tsutenkaku tower that draws inspiration from the Eiffel Tower. As evening falls, the neon-lit Dotonburi district beckons. The famous Glico running man billboard overlooks a canal with bright boats. Tourists mill around to snap a picture in front of the famous sign. Joining the traditional billboards here are LED lit and 3D billboards. The store fronts and facades too are a touch dramatic with 3D effect, life-size octopus, gyoza, and faces of people. A cool breeze blows from the river and I make my way to the covered Sinsaibashi-suji shopping street where you find high street brands, cosmetic shops, and food stalls. Like in Tokyo, the Onitsuka Tiger showroom here is packed with people. I queue up too, jostle for space inside and confuse myself with the metallic options. But one cannot take too long to decide because while you do, what you want may just be whisked away to the billing counter, right in front of your eyes! I could linger at Sinsaibashi for longer but the idea of sundowners at Bar Bota at the Four Seasons, seems inviting. The bar serves cocktails crafted with local botanicals, innovative snacks and stellar views of Osaka gilded by the sun’s orange rays. Post that, I reward myself with a massage. At the spa on the 36th floor, I let the masseuse work her magic while I look out of the floor-to-ceiling windows. The city lights come on, clouds waft through the late evening sky, and eventually a gentle snore escapes my mouth. Good night, Osaka!

The writer was in Japan at the invitation of Four Seasons Hotels and Resorts

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It is James Bond and *Diamonds Are Forever* that one thinks of when getting off the plane at Louisville Muhammad Ali International Airport, where a fluttering banner proclaims ‘Welcome to Bourbon City’. In the novel, Bond finds himself in Saratoga Springs and is introduced to a drink that is “fashionable in racing circles – bourbon and branch water”. Bond is obviously not swigging vodka martinis, shaken or stirred, all the time. Louisville is known for bourbon, the Kentucky Derby, boxing legend Muhammad Ali and of course Kentucky Fried Chicken, considering it is the final resting place of Colonel Sanders, founder of KFC. Dinner at Paseo set the ball rolling with a cocktail-forward approach. The Paper Plane’s citrusy notes elegantly paired with the heirloom tomato toast while the Mule’s Vodka, lime, and ginger beer offered an exquisite counterpoint to the earthiness of the black garlic Caesar. The Old Fashioned was all sugar and spice when paired with the creamy risotto. The next day as we drove into the Buffalo Trace Distillery in Frankfort for a tour, we were greeted by the historical water tower that has stood strong and tall since the 1700s. The buffalo icon on the water tower is a nod to the actual buffalo migration routes, or traces, that gave the distillery its name. Incidentally the buffalo mascot is called Thunder. The tour includes stops at Old Fire Copper Distillery, Old Taylor, a restored fermenter and Warehouse C from the late 1800s, with tastings along the way. After a lunch of bourbon scalloped potatoes, mushrooms and a generous helping of bourbon



Bonding over bourbon

Louisville presents a whisky-soaked adventure with a side of Bond and a splash of Bob Dylan

butter bread pudding we headed to Whiskey Woodcraft, where master woodcrafter Jonathan Hartman and his team give used bourbon barrels a new life by creating custom pieces. A tour of Old Taylor House gave us a sense of the history of the place. Dating to the late 1700s, it is one of the oldest buildings in Frankfort (nothing to do with the German city). The Bourbon boat tour, the only water-based distillery-related tour in the US, on the Kentucky River gave a sense of spirited history. It is said that on the nine-month river journey to New Orleans, the clear whisky absorbed the colour and flavour of the barrels that were charred to sanitise, to take on the well known golden hue and smoky

flavour. Dinner at The Barrel Room at the historically significant Repeal, featured steaks cooked over reclaimed oak bourbon barrels. A dash of history Bourbon Pompeii thankfully does not feature lovers in an ashy embrace for eternity or even that poor petrified dog; instead it is the site of a whisky archaeological discovery – the remains of Colonel EH Taylor Jr’s original OFC (Old Fire Copper) Distillery, dating back to the 1870s. Taylor, called the Father of Bourbon, introduced many revolutionary practices into the making of bourbon. The remains of the distillery



were discovered in 2016 when Buffalo Trace began renovating an empty building as an event space. We were taken through the site over gantries to look at the 11,000-gallon copper-lined fermenter, among other things, by Nicolas Laracuent, also known as The Bourbon Archaeologist. Laracuent was doing his doctorate when he was invited by Buffalo Trace to have a look at the remains of the old distillery. Racing finish A visit to the Pin Oak Stud Farm introduced us to Kentucky’s other

(Clockwise from far left) A picture of the buffalo mantel painting in Stony point; a historic steamboat on the river; delivery office of the George T Staggs; and the mash at the distillery tour. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

passion – racing. As we looked at the beautiful beasts and learnt interesting things, such as all horses have a January 1 birthday, I was again reminded of *Diamonds Are Forever* and the horse, Shy Smile that Bond’s friend and ex-CIA man, Felix Leiter, comes to Saratoga to investigate. We ended the day at the aptly named The Last Refuge. The whisky bar in Louisville’s NuLu district is located in a repurposed German Methodist church from the 1880s. The pulpit, the stained glass windows, the soaring, painted ceiling and the slightly startled-looking saints, apart from the walls of bejewelled whisky bottles earns the bar its title of High Church of Bourbon. Troubadour tales And there is the Bob Dylan connection, as giant portraits of his 1960s strung-out look adorn the space, which is also home to Heaven’s Door, a whisky the singer and songwriter co-created in 2018. For those curious about the ‘water of life’, a distillery tour might just be the ticket for whisky newbies like yours truly and seasoned connoisseurs alike, to uncover its origins and what makes it different from its Scottish cousin. And if you find yourself thinking of a certain secret agent with stormy blue eyes, a cruel mouth, and an unruly comma of dark hair... that just adds to the suave quotient, bruv. The writer was in Louisville at the invitation of Buffalo Trace Distillery

Wuthering Heights

Director: Emerald Fennell

Cast: Margot Robbie, Jacob Elordi, Hong Chau, Shazad Latif, Alison Oliver, Martin Clunes, Ewan Mitchell

Storyline: A foundling and the daughter of the house fall in love to the destruction of all concerned



A synthetic adaptation

English

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Emerald Fennell's *Wuthering Heights* wears its carnality self-consciously on its sleeve. A phenomenally loose adaptation of Emily Brontë's 1847 novel, *Wuthering Heights* is eye-wateringly beautiful to look at and sounds exquisite but is ultimately rather hollow.

After a hanging, which amuses and excites young Catherine (Charlotte Mellington) and her paid companion, Nelly (Vy Nguyen), they head back to their gracious home, Wuthering Heights on the moors.

Catherine's father, Earnshaw (Martin Clunes) is

an alcoholic and gambler. When he returns home with a boy (Owen Cooper) who was being abused on the streets of Liverpool, the household is all in a lather.

Catherine takes to the boy and names him Heathcliff after her dead brother and Earnshaw says Heathcliff can be Cathy's pet. As the years pass, the two become close while Earnshaw's addictions drive Wuthering Heights to rack and ruin.

New neighbours at Thrushcross Grange, textile merchant Edgar Linton (Shazad Latif) and his ward, Isabella (Alison Oliver), give the now grown up Cathy (Margot Robbie) the idea of marrying Edgar as a way out of poverty, much to Heathcliff's (Jacob Elordi) anger.

Upon hearing Cathy tell Nelly (Hong Chau) that marrying him would degrade her, and not

hearing her later confession of love for him, Heathcliff rides away into the sunset. Cathy marries Edgar and lives a good but empty life till a well-groomed and mysteriously wealthy Heathcliff returns to upset the domestic applearc.

For all the sweaty couplings in the film, *Wuthering Heights* is strangely without heat. Casting Nelly as the villain of the piece does not give any radical insight.

Where *Wuthering Heights* soars is in its framing, with Linus Sandgren's extremely tight close-ups jostling with expansive wide shots, and explosive music (Anthony Willis, score, Charli XCX, songs).

The moors, the rocks, the gracious crumbling ruin that is Wuthering Heights, and Thrushcross Grange, with its blood-red floor, fireplace of hands, the green-and-gold canopied bed, and

wallpaper designed to look like Catherine's face (down to the mole, decidedly creepy), are a treat for the senses.

The clothes are lovely too from Cathy's anachronistic wedding dress (the shot of her walking to the Grange with her veil billowing behind her is breathtaking), to the black velvet gown that almost looks like latex.

This is not so much an adaptation or reimagining of Brontë's Gothic tale of toxic love fueling an unhealthy desire for revenge as much as Fennell's hope of what Heathcliff and Cathy coulda, shoulda, woulda got up to in windswept Yorkshire.

Even if you remove Brontë from the mix, the tragedy of *Wuthering Heights* is, it does not stand very well on its own. It is just a well dressed, beautifully shot, and superbly scored, yet ultimately lifeless costume drama.

Wuthering Heights is currently running in theatres

Snippets



The Paradise: Nani-Srikanth Odela movie gets new release date

The *Paradise*, the much-awaited action thriller starring Nani, has been postponed. The film team announced a new theatrical release date of the pan-Indian movie.

The makers shared the update on *Instagram* along with a new release poster, explaining the reason behind the delay. "We don't want to rush. We need time to deliver it," the caption read. Earlier slated to release on March 26, 2026, the movie, directed by Srikanth Odela, will hit the screens on August 21, 2026.

Odela had previously worked with Nani in the hit rural action drama *Dasara* (2023). *The Paradise* is produced by Sudhakar Cherukuri under the SLV Cinemas banner. In *The Paradise*, Nani plays Dhagad.



Sanjay Leela Bhansali teams up with Ketan Mehta for Jai Somnath

Sanjay Leela Bhansali will be producing a historical-drama, *Jai Somnath*, his banner Bhansali Productions announced recently. Written and directed by Ketan Mehta, the film traces the period between 1025-1026 AD, when Mahmud of Ghazni attacked and plundered the Somnath temple in Gujarat.

The makers made the announcement with a post on its Instagram handle on Sunday. "A temple can be broken, not the faith," read the caption to the post.

The film is set to be released in 2027 and is produced by Bhansali Productions and Maya Movies.

Bhansali's last directorial was *Heeramandi*.



Ashwiny Iyer Tiwari curates 'Femme Lens' at Red Lorry Film Festival 2026

The Red Lorry Film Festival (RLFF) returns to Mumbai from March 13 to 15, 2026, with a renewed focus on women-led cinema through its dedicated Femme Lens category. Curated by filmmaker Ashwiny Iyer Tiwari, the section brings together a diverse slate of fiction, documentary and cross-genre films directed by women from India and around the world.

The international line-up includes *Peak Everything*, *Isola*, *The Portuguese House* and *The Remnants of You*, which also feature as part of the festival's Hola Spain collaboration.

Indian cinema is represented through *Turtle Walker*.



Sisterhood, suspense and sass

Roisin Gallagher, Sinéad Keenan and Caoilfhionn Dunne as the three friends haring around Ireland, uncovering the secret behind a fourth friend's death

English

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Saoirse (Roisin Gallagher), Robyn (Sinéad Keenan) and Dara (Caoilfhionn Dunne) have been close friends since school. Twenty years on, and in their late 30s now, they have remained close.

Saoirse is a successful writer with a hit television show, called *Murder Code* to her credit, and is all set to marry Seb (Tom Basden). Robyn is married to a man who adores her and has three children while Dara "does something in computers" and looks after her mum.

When the trio hear that a close friend from school, Greta (Natasha O'Keeffe), who they were estranged from after a scary event, is dead, they decide to go to the wake. When they get to the wake in Knockdara in Donegal, everything seems off and Greta's family behave strangely.

Greta's husband, Owen (Emmett J. Scanlan), is the police chief at Knockdara and seems to know more than he says. Is the body in the coffin, Greta or someone else? If it is someone else, where is Greta? How does Jodie (Selin Hizli) who seems to have met Greta the day she died, fit into

How to Get to Heaven from Belfast

Creator: Lisa McGee

Cast: Roisin Gallagher, Sinéad Keenan, Caoilfhionn Dunne

Episodes: 8

Storyline: Three friends attend the wake of a girl they knew in school and want to ensure a secret they shared as girls remains buried

all this?

Do the present events have anything to do with the fire and the scary cabin in the woods 20 years ago? There is a sigil that the girls have tattooed on them which seems to pop up at inopportune times.

Apart from multiple trips between Belfast and Donegal, the hunt for truth takes our amateur sleuths to a swanky resort in Portugal, to a nursing home, a lighthouse, and a ruined village called Caille Neamh where the veil between heaven and earth is thin.

There is a scary assassin-type person called Booker (Bronagh Gallagher) who invariably seems a hair's breadth away from killing the friends or random others. While Booker is all business, her protégé, Feeney (Saoirse-Monica Jackson), with her taste for outrageous hair and makeup, and ice cream, is at the other end of the spectrum.

Saoirse feels her heart skip a beat every time she sees the handsome Knockdara policeman, Liam (Darragh Hand). We see Margo (Michelle Fairley), conducting psychological experiments on Greta when she was a child.

Apart from the mystery of Greta's disappearance, there is also Andrew (Josh Finan) looking for his father, an investigative journalist, who disappeared 20 years ago, around the time of the fire in the cabin in the woods. That he looks eerily like Jason Meadows, Greta's

possibly abusive boyfriend, is yet another curveball.

While the mystery will not stand up to even casual scrutiny, and the final episodes go slightly haywire, Lisa McGee, who also is behind the popular period teen drama *Derry Girls*, has fun in her sandbox of social commentary, intergenerational trauma, and female friendships.

One cannot help but laugh when Dara has "an attack of the Catholics", a landline is described as a "Portuguese ornament", DNA is compared to Catholicism ("It doesn't wash off"), and Dara's comment when Saoirse talks of "Doubting Peters" (har har): "There's lapsed Catholicism and then there's you."

The aerial shots of Ireland are breathtaking, the pop songs invigorating and nostalgic, the chaotic action bracing, and the many call backs to *Derry Girls* thrilling. The acting might sometimes tip into the unnecessarily loud, but overall it moves smoothly enough.

When all has been answered, including how to correctly pronounce Saoirse and the fact that Irish police are called the Garda, only one question remains, namely, what is in the pink bag, and that will only be answered in Season 2.

How to Get to Heaven From Belfast currently streams on Netflix